

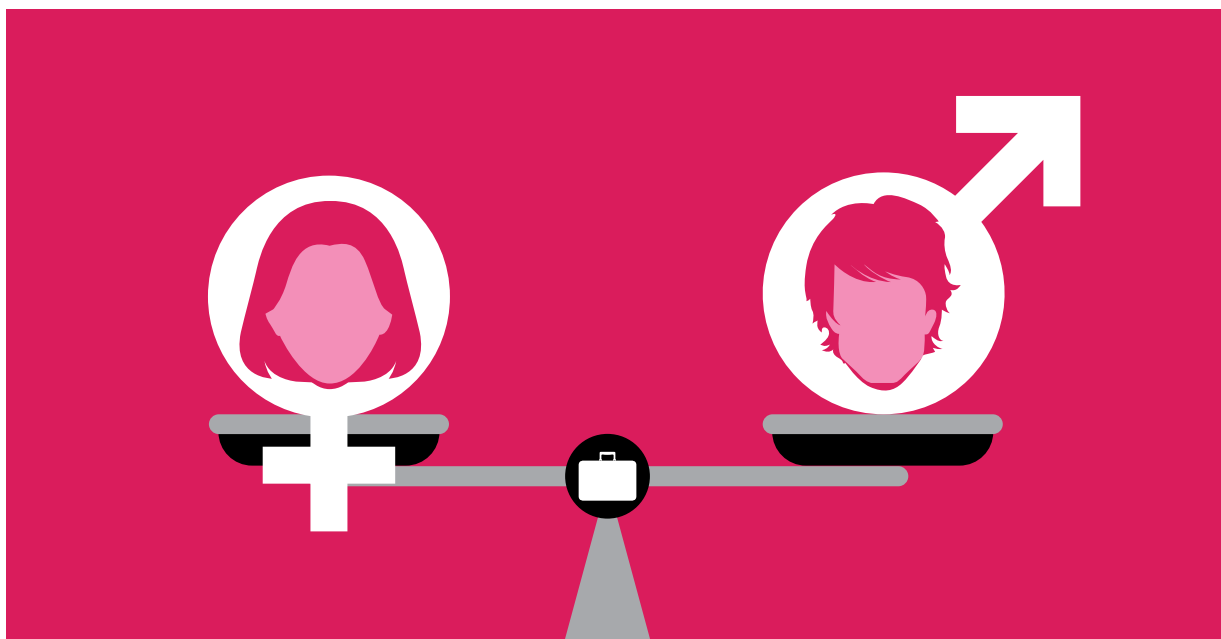


ILLUSTRATION BY **RAJ VERMA**

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women in the corporate world face. Further, inputs can be shared by women leaders for practical training, networking platforms and real-world business operations exposure for the students. Such collaborations can help B-schools identify the required core skills to empower women to confidently march on as executives.

Female-led start-ups promoted by B-schools and encouragement of entrepreneurship among women through specialised courses, workshops and mentorship programmes aimed at fostering entrepreneurship are critical steps. Further, through a strategic collaboration approach, it is possible for the institutions to provide access to funding, start-up incubators and industry networks to young women.

The biggest hurdle that women face in the corporate world is the challenge of stereotyping. The general perception is that women are less capable and dynamic as leaders than their male counterparts. B-schools can help in raising awareness at an early level and help create a more level field for women in leadership positions.

There is no greater encouragement than learning about something from people who have done it themselves. During my early professional days, most organisations were completely male-dominated. I was always the single woman in the room and not provided with any skills or tools with which I could navigate situations. Today, given that several women have graduated from these institutions, there is a possibility of scaffolding and networking. It is possible for women leaders to come and mentor women in these colleges, even before they enter the corporate world.

Another important aspect of improving gender parity is to provide strong career support services. Career development workshops, networking events, recruitment *melas*, and other such initiatives that connect women executives undertaking courses like MBA with commensurate

job opportunities and facilitate interactions with industry leaders, can be major boosters for future women leaders. Women can also benefit from specialised leadership development programmes.

To build an ecosystem that enables women to overcome bias in corporate leadership, the first step is to balance out the faculty's gender diversity. An inclusive learning environment can serve as an ideal launch pad for women executives to take up key roles in the business world. Often, there is no conversation about how organisational culture must discuss diversity on a broader level. Everyone from professors to students and companies must join in the conversations and ensure that diversity is also about hiring the best for the role, irrespective of their gender. In this respect, start-ups are a little more gender-neutral and inclusive.

Here I must also mention the importance of groups on various social media platforms. For instance, Facebook has a group called Women from IIMs. Such groups can help in experience sharing and navigating personal and professional queries. They can also facilitate one-on-one interactions for those who need it.

In conclusion, the National Sample Survey Office shows about 26 per cent of Indian women being formally employed. Some reasons for such a low share are factors such as lack of education and opportunities, familial responsibilities and cultural barriers within local circles; these need to be overcome. When a system of inclusivity, experience sharing and openness is built within the education system, it will percolate to the organisational level. By doing so, India can fully leverage the extensive workforce available in the country and enjoy the profitability and growth that businesses with women in leadership positions enjoy. **BT**

Views are personal